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retains its literal meaning, while the other component is used figuratively. These expressions are therefore borderline cases between collocations and idioms. They may therefore be termed ‘semi-idioms’, e.g., *יש רגלים לדבר* *yeš raglayim la-davar* ‘there is something true/correct in this matter (lit. “the matter has legs”); *חיפש בנרות* *xipeš be-nerot* ‘search high and low (lit. “to look for with candles”); *הטיל ספק* *heṭil safeq* ‘to cast doubt’.

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Idioms: Biblical Hebrew

Idioms are conventionalized phrases with limited compositionality, that is, with meanings which cannot be directly derived from the

meanings of their parts. They occur throughout the Hebrew Bible, and a number of Biblical Hebrew idioms also appear in New Testament Greek, in other texts influenced by the Bible, and ultimately, through literal translations, in modern languages. Though integral to Biblical Hebrew discursive and poetic language, idioms are often poorly understood and translated.

Idiomatic language may be taken more broadly to include a range of figures of speech in elevated, poetic, hyperbolic, or euphemistic language. These may include a wide range of metaphors, metonyms (particularly those for the person, such as *נפש* *nepeš* ‘throat’, and psychology, such as *לב* *lēb* ‘heart’, *כבד* *kābēd* ‘liver’, *כליות* *kalāyōt* ‘kidneys’, and *מעים* *mē‘ayim* ‘intestines’) and other body images, metaphors for psychological states (*צר* *šar* ‘narrow’ and *הרחיב* *harhīb* ‘widen’ for distress and ease, respectively), and stereotypical actions (*יָצָא* *yāšā’* ‘to go out’ and *בוא* *bō’* ‘to come in’ referring to military campaigns). Most of these types contribute to the meaning of idioms proper.

1. FORM

Biblical Hebrew idioms frequently take the form of a verb phrase, with a body part as object, as in *נָשָׂא פָנִים* *nāšā pānīm* ‘to lift someone’s face’, *גָּלָה אָזֶן* *gālā ‘ōzen* ‘to expose someone’s ear’, *נָטָה יָד עַל* *nātā yād ‘al* ‘to stretch out one’s hand against’, or *דִּבֶּר עַל־לֵב* *dibbēr ‘al-lēb* ‘to speak on someone’s heart’. Most are not rigid “idiomatic phrases”, but “idiomatically combining expressions” (Nunberg, Sag, and Wasow 1994), which can be syntactically and semantically *decomposed* to a limited extent. Thus their *syntactic form* is not completely fixed, so one may find forms exhibiting topicalization, such as *וְהַיָּד הַנְּטוּיָה עַל־* *wa-ḥay-yād han-nəṭūyā ‘al-* ‘and this is the hand which is stretched out against’ (Isa. 14.26), or nominalization, such as *נָשָׂא פָנִים* *nāšū pānīm* ‘lifted of face’ (2 Kgs 5.1). Their *semantics* is also partly compositional, in that it derives to some extent from the meaning of the verb and the metaphorical meanings carried by the body-part.

The *verb* is typically one which refers to a very basic or general action concept, such as verbs of position and motion (*עָמַד* *‘amad* ‘to stand’, *יָצָא* *yāšā’* ‘to go out’, *בוא* *bō’* ‘to come in’), displacement (*נָטָה* *nātā’* ‘to stretch out’, *נָשָׂא* *nāšā’* ‘to lift’, *פָּרַשׁ* *pāraš* ‘to spread out’,

רום *rūm* ‘to rise’, רחב *rāḥab* ‘to be wide’, שים *šim* ‘to put’, שלח *šālāḥ* ‘to send’, hiding and revealing (גלה *gālā* ‘to expose’, העלים *he’elim* ‘to conceal’, הסתיר *histir* ‘to hide’), and hardening (חזק *hāzaq* ‘to be strong’, קשה *qāšā* ‘to be hard’). The abstract properties represented by the body part themselves carry the semantic weight of the phrase (in the four examples in the preceding paragraph, for example, *status*, *awareness*, *power*, and *emotions*), and the idiom usually refers simply to a change in the state, position, perceptibility, or other relations of that property (here, *raising*, *revealing*, *exercising*, and *addressing*). The most productive verb in creating idioms with body parts appears to be נשא *nāšā* ‘to lift’, which combines with עין *‘ayin* ‘eye’, עפעפים *ap’appayim* ‘eye-lashes’, קול *qōl* ‘voice’, פנים *pānīm* ‘face’, ראש *rōš* ‘head’, יד *yād* ‘hand’, רגל *regel* ‘foot’, לב *lēb* ‘heart’, בשר *bāšār* ‘flesh’, פה *pe* ‘mouth’, and שפה *šāpā* ‘lip’ (Lübbe 2002).

There are other types of idioms, not involving body parts, which exploit the metaphorical meanings of the *verbal concept* itself. This may be a very basic action (e.g., כרת *kārat* ‘to cut’ also used to mean ‘eradicate [a people or land]’, ‘cut off [a person from his or her people]’, as well as ‘formalize [a covenant]’) or a bodily function such as one of the senses or ingestion (e.g., וינקת חלב גוים *wā-yānaqt ḥālēb gōyīm* ‘you [fs] will suckle the milk of nations’ [Isa. 60.16]). Some such verbal concepts may be highly productive in forming idioms (e.g., שבר על *šābar ‘ol* ‘to break the yoke’ [Jer. 5.5], נתק מוסרות *nātaq mōsērōt* ‘to burst bonds’ [Jer. 5.5; Ps. 2.3], נתיק מוטה *nittēq mōtā* ‘to shatter the yoke’ [Isa. 58.6]).

As for the *body parts* involved, the most common are those which serve for the senses (אזן *‘ōzen* ‘ear’, עין *‘ayin* ‘eye’), communication (לשון *lāšōn* ‘tongue’, שפה *šāpā* ‘lip’, פה *pe* ‘mouth’), and action (יד *yād* ‘hand’, כף *kaḥ* ‘palm’, רגל *regel* ‘foot’), and those most strongly endowed with psychophysical associations (לב *lēb* ‘heart’, נפש *nepeš* ‘throat’, פנים *pānīm* ‘face’, ראש *rōš* ‘head’). However, it seems that almost any part of the body (even those of animals, such as קרן *qeren* ‘horn’ and כנף *kānāp* ‘wing’) can bear a metaphorical meaning, be it *spatial* (e.g., פנים *pānīm* ‘face’ for *front*, יד *yād* ‘hand’ for *side*), *functional* (e.g., יד *yād* ‘hand’ for *act*, *express power*, קרן *qeren* ‘horn’ for *be*

powerful, לשון *lāšōn* ‘tongue’ for *speak*), or *psychophysical* (e.g., לב *lēb* ‘heart’ for *thinking*, עין *‘ayin* ‘eye’ for *knowing*, ערף *‘ōreḥ* ‘neck’ for *pride*). These metaphorical meanings of body parts also appear in denominative verbs (e.g., האזין *he’ezin* ‘to listen’ from אָזַן *‘ōzen* ‘ear’, רחם *riḥam* ‘to take pity on’ from רֶחֶם *reḥem* ‘womb’, ערף *‘ārāḥ* ‘to break the neck of’ from עֶרֶף *‘ōreḥ* ‘neck’) and in prepositional phrases (e.g., לפני *li-ḥnē* ‘in front of’ from פָּנִים *pānīm* ‘face’, בְּיָד *bā-yād* ‘by means of’ from יָד *yād* ‘hand’).

2. INTERPRETATION

The interpretation of idioms is made difficult by their limited compositionality, their dependence on opaque metonyms, their cultural specificity (making the value of comparative Ancient Near Eastern data questionable), and their frequently highly literal translation in the Septuagint. Hence interpretation typically depends heavily on the context, especially terms used in synonymous parallelism in poetry, and features (especially sociolinguistic features) of the real-world context in narrative. However, a prototypical metonymous meaning of the body-part is still usually discernible, as are some typical characteristics of the verb.

Idioms may exhibit greater *polysemy* than other forms of language, having been perhaps particularly susceptible to taking on new meanings in the diverse historical, geographical, and cultural contexts from which the Biblical Hebrew corpus derives. They also exhibit a particularly high semantic potential under transitivization within the conceptual space *self-God-enemy* so characteristic of Biblical Hebrew prayer, and in relation to symbolic or ritual gestures. Thus נשא פנים *nāšā pānīm* ‘to lift someone’s face’ may mean *to show favor* (Ps. 4.7), *to show partiality* (Lev. 19.15), *to spare* (Deut. 28.50), *to grant a request* (Gen. 19.21), *to feel confident* (Job 11.15), or *to be powerful* (2 Kgs 5.1). נשא ראש *nāšā rōš* ‘to lift someone’s head’ may mean *to count* (Num. 1.2), *to release (from prison)* (2 Kgs 25.27; cf. Jer. 52.31), *to attack* (Ps. 83.3), or *to be confident* (Job 10.15). And יד נשא *nāšā yād* ‘to lift one’s hand’ may mean *to beg* (Ps. 28.2), *to respect* (Ps. 119.48), *to attack* (2 Sam. 18.28), *to exercise power* (Ps. 10.12), *to swear* (Deut. 32.40), or *to bless (people)* (Lev. 9.22).

The last of these meanings, *to bless (people)*, expressed as **יָד נָשָׂא** *nāśā yād* ‘to lift one’s hand’, is paralleled by **כַּף נָשָׂא** *nāśā kaḥ* ‘to lift one’s palm’ (Ps. 63.5) and **יָד הֶעֱלָה** *he’ēlā yād* ‘to raise one’s hand’ (Neh. 8.6), both meaning *to praise (God)*. Similarly, the meaning *to desire eagerly* may be expressed by **פֶּתַח פָּתַח** *pātaḥ pe* ‘to open one’s mouth’ (Ps. 119.131), **פֶּה פָּעַר** *pā’ar pe* ‘to widen one’s mouth’ (Isa. 5.14), or **פֶּה פָּצָה** *pāšā pe* ‘to open one’s mouth’ (Ps. 22.14). Thus idioms are partially *decomposable*, and synonymy within the verbal element (**פֶּתַח** *pātaḥ* / **פָּעַר** *pā’ar* / **פָּצָה** *pāšā*, all meaning essentially ‘to open’) or the nominal element (**יָד** *yād* / **כַּף** *kaḥ*, the former typically rendered ‘hand’ and the latter ‘palm’) with another idiom may legitimately contribute to interpretation.

3. WORDPLAY

The polysemy of idioms, and the interplay of idiomatic and literal meanings, makes them highly effective in wordplay. Most well-known, perhaps, is Joseph’s use of the expression **נָשָׂא רֹאשׁ** *nāśā rōš* ‘to lift one’s head’ to mean as an idiom *to release (from prison)* in the case of the cupbearer, and literally in the case of the baker (Gen. 40.13, 19). Here, the idiomatic sense derives from metaphorical senses of *both* of the terms **נָשָׂא** *nāśā* ‘to lift’ (hence *elevate socially*) and **רֹאשׁ** *rōš* ‘head’ (hence *status*), such that *both* contrast with the brutally literal sense *to lift the head*, making the wordplay all the more effective (Marcus 1990). Less well-known is the phrase **גָּנַב לֵב** *gānab lēb* / **לֵב גָּנַב** *lēb gānab* ‘to steal heart’ (Gen. 31.20, 26). In v. 20, it rather clearly has the idiomatic meaning of *to deceive*. However, in v. 26, it stands in parallel to **נִהַג בָּנוֹת** *nihaḡ bānōt* ‘to abduct daughters’, suggesting a *double entendre* between Jacob’s *deception* and his literally *stealing* Laban’s *heart* (as a metaphor for his daughters). The reduced form **גָּנַב** *gānab* ‘to steal’ alone in v. 27 continues the wordplay (cf. also Gen. 30.33).

4. TRANSLATION

The translation of idioms has typically suffered greatly from literalism. **אָרְךָ אֵפִים** *erek’ appayim* ‘long of nostrils’ (Exod. 34.6) has never been translated literally, perhaps due to the well accepted metaphorical meaning of **אָף** *aḥ* ‘nose,

nostril’ as *anger*, and is usually rendered ‘long-suffering’, ‘slow to anger’, or ‘patient’. **רַע עֵינַי** *ra’ āyin* ‘bad of eye’ (Prov. 23.6) was translated literally in KJV (1611), but appears more helpfully as ‘stingy’ in more recent translations. **עָמַד בְּדֶרֶךְ** *āmaḍ bad-derek* ‘to stand in the way of’ (Ps. 1.1) was translated literally even in NIV (1984), following RSV (1952), resulting in an unfortunate clash with the English idiomatic meaning of this phrase, viz., *obstruct* (thus a blessing is pronounced on a person who does not obstruct the wicked!); this was corrected in NRSV (1989), but the error was repeated in ESV (2001). Finally, literal translations of particularly graphic idioms such as **כָּרַת שְׁפָתַיִם** *kārat šəpātayim* ‘to cut lips’ and **כָּרַת לָשׁוֹן** *kārat lāšōn* ‘to cut tongue’ (Ps. 12.4) might often be considered unproblematic; however, translators may be forced to reconsider when working in a context such as that of the civil war in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, where very inappropriate associations are evoked (Mabele 2003).

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Idioms: Modern Hebrew

Idioms represent a distinct lexical category, typically comprised of several words which bear a new meaning or connotation. To quote Webster’s dictionary, an idiom is “an expression whose meaning is not predictable from the usual meanings of its constituent elements, as *kick the bucket* or *hang one’s head*”.